

Questions and Answers on the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL)

December 2024

As UNIFIL works to fulfill its mandate in southern Lebanon, false or misleading assertions about the mission have impacted its operations and compromised the safety and security of UN personnel and premises. These false narratives about UNIFIL inflame mistrust, disrupt the pursuit of political solutions, reduce the ability of the mission to do its job and endanger lives.

This page provides factual answers to common questions and themes that have appeared in recent media commentary and coverage.

Is resolution 1701 now obsolete, since the cessation of hostilities signed by Lebanon and Israel on 27 November 2024?

Security Council resolution 1701 remains the agreed-upon framework for achieving peace and stability, and all parties have committed to its implementation. All the main provisions of resolution 1701 – security, stability, long term solutions, support for the LAF – are still valid. The responsibility for carrying out the terms of the resolution falls to the parties themselves, not solely to UNIFIL.

UNIFIL is taking part in the reformulated and enhanced tripartite mechanism established by the cessation of hostilities that entered into force on 27 November. The mechanism is chaired by the United States, and also includes France, Israel and Lebanon.

The cessation of hostilities document is consistent with, and reinforces, resolution 1701. Indeed, any progress in reducing armed presence in southern Lebanon depends on the commitment of all parties to fully implement resolution 1701 and work towards a lasting political solution.

Neither Israel nor Lebanon has fully implemented all provisions required by resolution 1701, and daily exchanges of fire by Hizbullah and other non-state armed groups, along with Israeli Defense Forces incursions across the Blue Line into Lebanon, are clear violations of this resolution.

The UN urges all actors to fully implement the cessation of hostilities and commitments within the framework of 1701.

Has UNIFIL failed to implement Security Council resolution 1701?

Implementation of resolution 1701 is first and foremost the responsibility of the parties, the government of Israel and the government of Lebanon. UNIFIL supports the parties

Commented [NM1]: Delete? Does Israel still support it?

Commented [NB1R2]: Suggest keeping.

Commented [ND1R3]: Yes Israel still supports it and has said so consistently in meetings.

Commented [NB2]: Do we need to say this?

Commented [ND2R2]: Absolutely There have been at least six other non state armed groups firing rockets etc at Hizbullah across the BL over the last year.

Commented [ND2R3]: Palestinian groups and Lebanese ones.

Commented [NM3]: Some of these allegations are too broad - e.g. this one overlaps with the following two allegations, which makes the answers also overlapping. I'll adjust.

in the implementation of the cessation of hostilities established through resolution 1701

It is important to understand what Security Council resolution 1701 (2006) is and says. You can read more about it [here](#). The resolution sets out a framework for a cessation of hostilities between Hizbullah and Israel. The cessation of hostilities involves – among other elements – the withdrawal of Hizbullah and Israeli forces from southern Lebanon, and the deployment of Lebanese Armed Forces into that area.

Resolution 1701 aims to stabilize the situation in southern Lebanon, and create space for Israel and Lebanon to move from cessation of hostilities, agree on a permanent ceasefire and to promote a long-term solution.

While a peacekeeping operation can support diplomatic efforts, it is no substitute for a political process and a political solution. Only the parties can achieve lasting and sustainable peace.

UNIFIL's mandate, as defined by resolution 1701, is to monitor, support, and report on the resolution's implementation, including by:

- monitoring the cessation of hostilities
- supporting the Lebanese government and Lebanese Armed Forces as they deploy in the South
- Extending its assistance to help ensure humanitarian access to civilian populations.
- Coordinating its activities with the Governments of Lebanon and Israel.

So, what has UNIFIL done in the past 18 years?

Over the past 18 years, UNIFIL has made significant contributions to maintaining stability in southern Lebanon, which had seen one of its quietest periods in recent decades until the current escalation of hostilities.

UNIFIL has convened regular meetings between the Israel Defense Forces and the Lebanese Armed Forces. These “deconfliction” meetings have been a key confidence-building measure that have helped maintain open lines of communication, mitigated potential escalations, prevent misunderstandings and discuss outstanding issues related to implementation of 1701 and Blue Line marking. Through its liaison and coordination mechanisms, UNIFIL remains the only channel through which the Lebanese and Israeli armies communicate.

UNIFIL has also worked with the parties to visibly mark more than half of the Blue Line to prevent violations, clarifying boundaries and reducing tensions along the Blue Line.

In close coordination with the LAF, UNIFIL peacekeepers have patrolled southern Lebanon to monitor what has been happening on the ground and impartially report violations of resolution 1701 to the UN Security Council.

Commented [LD4]: This is from the UNIFIL spox lines of the noon briefing last week

Peacekeepers also support the Lebanese Armed Forces and Navy through joint training, to improve their capacities, capabilities and help strengthen the LAF's deployment in south Lebanon and at sea so they can eventually take over the security tasks currently performed by peacekeepers

UNIFIL also has a Maritime Task Force, the first of its type in a UN peacekeeping mission, which supports the Lebanese navy to monitor Lebanon's territorial waters and prevent the entry into the area of operations of unauthorized arms and related material, including through capacity-building.

By establishing a secure environment, UNIFIL has also enabled various UN agencies and NGOs to deliver essential aid and services to local communities.

A lasting solution, however, ultimately depends on the commitment of all parties to fully implement resolution 1701.

Shouldn't UNIFIL have disarmed Hizbullah over the past 18 years?

UNIFIL does not have the mandate or authority to disarm non-state armed groups, including Hizbullah, by force.

UNIFIL peacekeepers are not authorized to enforce Security Council resolution 1701, or to disarm Hizbullah or any other non-state armed group in Lebanon. The UN Security Council has not given UNIFIL the mandate to take such enforcement actions. Instead, UNIFIL's role is to monitor, report, and support the parties in the implementation of the resolution. UNIFIL continues to report all violations and support diplomatic solutions. Any additional actions, such as stronger enforcement, would require a new mandate from the Security Council.

What has UNIFIL done to investigate Hizbullah activity near UN positions over the years?

UNIFIL's focus is on ensuring full respect for relevant provisions of resolution 1701. UNIFIL has reported all documented violations of the resolution to the Security Council including sites or activities of interest.

Any infrastructure or activity that appears to be in violation of Security Council resolution 1701 have been systematically reported to the Lebanese and Israeli authorities and to the UN Security Council.

Lebanon is a sovereign country with its own legal framework regarding private property. While UNIFIL stands ready to support Lebanese authorities in investigating these sites if permitted access, the mission cannot forcibly enter any location without credible evidence that actions leading to hostile activity are occurring there.

Resolution 1701 mandates that the Lebanese Armed Forces facilitate UNIFIL's access to locations of interest, but UNIFIL has not consistently received this authorization. The

Commented [NM5]: I am not sure this is strictly speaking true, given that 1701 says the missions should take all necessary action to ensure that its AoR is "not utilized for hostile activities of any kind"

Commented [NB5R2]: I think Naomi has a point. It's a question of political will. Suggest "UN Peacekeepers are not EXPLICITLY authorized to disarm...under 1701". Its not particularly satisfactory, but it has been a customary norm that UNIFIL has used for 15 years, ie "we are not authorized to disarm, that has to be the LAF" and this needs to be reflected in our answer to the question.

Commented [ND5R3]: This is an argument of Israel it relates to pp12. What is in the text has been our consistent line.

Commented [NB6]: To Naomi's earlier point, one could argue it doesn't—that in fact it would just need a more robust interpretation of the existing mandate. Maybe the could be "would require further political consultations with all stakeholders including the UNSC" rather than saying definitely a new mandate.

Commented [ND6R2]: Disarmament takes us into territory of a different resolution not related to UNIFIL - 1559. We should absolutely stay away from it. The SC will not give mandate to disarm to UNIFIL. It is also deemed to be an internal issue and for the Lebanese to resolve. Israel claims UNIFIL should disarm. We do not want to be echoing the position of one party or the other.

Commented [NM8]: Not to Israel?

Commented [NB8R2]: I leave to UNIFIL colleagues but I think we report to LAF and to UNSC per procedure.

Commented [ND8R3]: Lebanon and Israel

Mission has repeatedly requested access to certain sites and reported the lack of such approvals to the Security Council.

UNIFIL has reported on suspicious activities, including tunnels crossing the Blue Line, and activities related to the NGO “Green Without Borders” going back to [2019](#).

Since 2019, the Security Council has expressed concern that UNIFIL has not been able to access all relevant areas, and since 2020 has formally called on the Lebanese government to ensure UNIFIL’s full and prompt access to these sites.

UNIFIL remains committed to fulfilling its mandate, but access and enforcement ultimately depend on the cooperation of the Lebanese authorities and adherence to the established legal frameworks in place.

UNIFIL urges all parties to step up cooperation with the mission to enable compliance with the 27 November cessation of hostilities.

Does UNIFIL favour Hizbollah, or the IDF?

UNIFIL does not support or favour any state or non-state party. The Mission implements its mandate, which is to monitor and support the implementation of Security Council resolution 1701 by both Israel and Lebanon, in a strictly impartial manner.

There have been allegations online suggesting that UNIFIL has either supported Hizbullah, or Israel. Both are false. But we take any credible allegations seriously and, if reliable evidence is presented, will investigate thoroughly.

UNIFIL does not support or favour any party to the conflict and it does not favour military actions by either party.

UNIFIL’s positions, including its watchtowers and cameras, are used solely for peacekeeping purposes and for force protection consistent with the mandate given by the Security Council. UNIFIL peacekeepers are dedicated to their mission, and maintain independence from any party to conflict, including Hizbullah.

Similarly, UNIFIL was not involved in facilitating any Israeli operations, or the violation of Lebanese sovereignty. Disinformation and false rumours suggesting otherwise are both inaccurate and harmful, as they put UN peacekeepers in danger, and undermine UNIFIL’s role as an impartial force.

Why haven’t UNIFIL peacekeepers withdrawn from positions along the Blue Line when they were asked to do so? Haven’t they been accidentally injured as a result?

After consulting with relevant stakeholders, including troop contributing countries and Headquarters, UNIFIL’s Force Commander and Head of Mission decided to keep UN

Commented [LD9]: Should include maybe something like this as well as per spox lines?

While there is currently no basis for this claim, UNIFIL takes any credible allegations seriously and, if reliable evidence is presented, will investigate thoroughly,

peacekeepers in their 29 forward positions along the Blue Line, as mandated by the Security Council. During this period, UNIFIL positions were hit repeatedly, both by crossfire and, in some cases, by deliberate targeting by the IDF. UN property was damaged and a number of peacekeepers from several different TCCs were injured in separate incidents. All of the blue helmets recovered, but the risks are clear.

Commented [ND10]: I think this better reflects what we have been saying publicly, we have been clear that there has been targeting.

By choosing to stay, UNIFIL not only continues to fly the UN flag; it gives the peacekeepers the opportunity to execute their mandated tasks including assisting the local population, clearing roads and removing explosive remnants of war. Despite limited monitoring capabilities, UNIFIL was still able to report to the SC and provide humanitarian support to local population still present in south Lebanon and will step up these efforts now that cessation of hostilities is in place. The Security Council and TCCs have been united in their continued unequivocal support for UNIFIL and the safety and security of its peacekeepers.

Why can't UNIFIL patrol/move around/conduct activities without the LAF?

In fact, resolution 1701 authorises UNIFIL to conduct patrols independently.

The LAF have always been informed about UNIFIL activities in the Area of Operations. The Government of Lebanon has always agreed that UNIFIL can conduct activities within its area of operations independently. Still, since part of our role is to strengthen LAF capacities, we coordinate patrols and activities with the LAF in advance.

Aren't there certain places UNIFIL peacekeepers cannot go without Lebanese permission?

Peacekeepers have full freedom of movement based on the mandate and status of forces agreement (SOFA) signed by the Government of Lebanon and the United Nations in 1995.

Freedom of movement is necessary to fulfill the mandate requested by the Government of Lebanon.

Did UNIFIL's mandate change in 2022, making it an occupying force?

Security Council resolution 2650, adopted in 2022, and subsequent resolutions did not give UNIFIL new operational powers.

Resolution 2650 simply uses more direct language to remind parties of their existing obligations under prior Security Council resolutions and the status of forces agreement (SOFA) signed between the Lebanese Government and the United Nations. For example, resolution 2650 *"calls on the Government of Lebanon to facilitate UNIFIL's prompt and full access to sites requested by UNIFIL for the purpose of swift investigation, including all*

relevant locations north of the Blue Line related to the discovery of tunnels crossing the Blue Line which UNIFIL reported as a violation of resolution.”

Doesn't UNIFIL need LAF permission to do anything?

The Government of Lebanon has always agreed that UNIFIL can conduct activities within its area of operations independently. Still, since part of our role is to strengthen LAF capacities, we coordinate patrols and activities with the LAF in advance.

Isn't UNIFIL biased toward Israel?

Peacekeepers are impartial and uphold the mandate given to them by the United Nations Security Council. UNIFIL has implemented its mandate throughout its history in an impartial manner, which is required in order to maintain the trust and confidence of the Lebanese and Israeli authorities, particularly in the context of the tripartite mechanism which UNIFIL has chaired since 2006. UNIFIL records violations as they arise, regardless of the party that may have committed them, and reports them to the Security Council.

UNIFIL also protests violations. For example, Israeli overflights into Lebanese air space are violations of resolution 1701 as well as of Lebanese sovereignty. This issue has always been discussed during Tripartite forums and during bilateral meetings of the UNIFIL leadership with the parties.

Commented [NM11]: Deleted question bc it repeats this question.